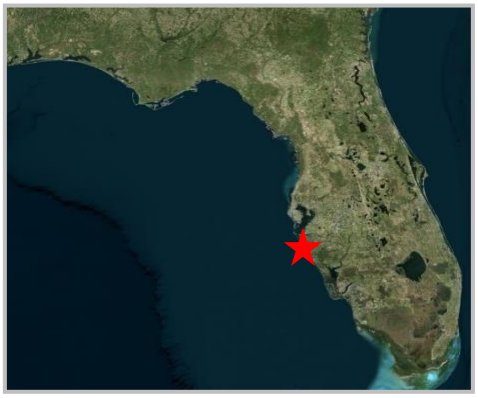
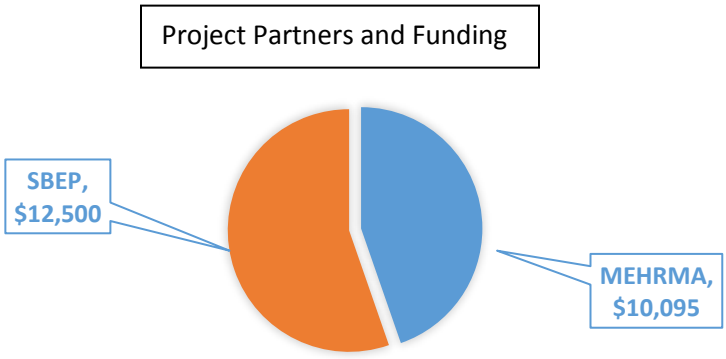
Sarasota Bay Oyster Habitat Restoration and Enhancement Project
Sarasota Bay, Manatee County, FL
FY 16/17





Project Description

The Sarasota Bay Oyster Habitat Restoration and Enhancement Project is located in the northern part of Sarasota Bay in Manatee County. The project site has intertidal and subtidal sandy bay bottom substrate and is surrounded by natural sloping shorelines which will allow for potential shoreward migration. The purpose of this project is to create four 20-foot-diameter oyster reef beds using approximately 34 tons of fossilized oyster shell. The habitat design of the oyster reef beds closely mimics the natural structure and functional elements of existing oyster habitat in Sarasota Bay. Each oyster reef bed is comprised of a continuous perimeter of bagged shell with loose shell material in the interior. The overall footprint of this project is approximately 1.2 acres of oyster habitat.



Figure 1: Placing bagged shell around the reef perimeter. April 24, 2017.

This project was started during Fiscal Year 2015-2016 as Marine and Estuarine Habitat Restoration, Monitoring and Assessment (MEHRMA) funds were used to purchase the 34 tons of fossilized oyster shell for $1,088.32. In addition, the Sarasota Bay Estuary Program (SBEP) funded and acquired all necessary permitting for this project. The remainder of this project was conducted during Fiscal Year 2016-2017, including purchasing of materials and construction of the oyster bags and oyster reef beds. SBEP's volunteer program, Bay Guardians, assisted in the construction and filling of the oyster bags.



Figure 2: Deploying fossilized oyster shell from a barge. April 28, 2017.



Figure 3: Finished oyster reefs. May 2, 2017.

Benefits

- Reduce wave energy.
- Protect the natural shoreline.
- Improve water quality and clarity.
- Provide substrate for the recruitment of oysters, sponges, and algae.
- Provide nursery and foraging habitat for a variety of wildlife including juvenile fish, invertebrates, oysters, and wading birds.

FWC Strategic Plan Elements Supported

Theme 1, Goal 1. Ensure the sustainability of Florida's fish and wildlife populations.

Theme 1, Goal 2. Ensure that sufficient habitat exists to support healthy populations of all native species of fish and wildlife.

Theme 3, Goal 3. Increase opportunities for residents and visitors, especially youth, to actively support and practice fish and wildlife conservation stewardship.

Theme 3, Goal 4. Encourage communities to conserve lands and waters critical to sustaining healthy and diverse populations of fish and wildlife.

Acreage restored by habitat type (footprint)

Approximately 0.03 acres of oyster habitat was created.

Acreage affected by restoration activities: 1.2 acres of adjacent oyster reef, seagrass, and sandy bay bottom.